



United States Department of Agriculture (USDA)
Office of the Chief Information Officer (OCIO)

Product Management and Human-Centered Design

Performance Work Statement (PWS)

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1 Background

USDA's Office of the Chief Information Officer (OCIO) seeks senior product management and human-centered design expertise to help inform and drive priority application development and modernization efforts across the Department. These efforts are aligned to high priority Departmental initiatives, including but not limited to the [Farmer's First Policy Agenda](#), and the [National Farm Security Action Plan](#). A primary vision of USDA OCIO is to streamline service delivery to the public through well-defined, automated, and repeatable enterprise service offerings that can be leveraged across the Department to meet multiple program delivery needs.

Initial areas of focus are Farm Production and Conservation (FPAC) Application Modernization efforts and prototypes within the Palantir environment to create data-centric, repeatable, and scalable service delivery across the entire portfolio of FPAC products and services. Some of these efforts could be applicable and scalable to other USDA mission areas. To determine the best approach and strategies to meet the OCIO mission, this effort must include key senior industry expertise in product management and human-centered design to ensure our efforts create the best products that fit the needs of our many different stakeholders across USDA programs.

2 Scope

The scope of this requirement includes provision of the following capabilities:

- **Senior Product Management** to lead product governance, roadmap development, and integration of Palantir ontology-driven workflows, ensuring alignment with OCIO objectives and compliance standards.
- **Human-Centered Design Expertise** to conduct user research, develop service design artifacts, and ensure accessibility compliance (Section 508).

The contractor must support agile delivery, produce documented deliverables, and operate within USDA security and governance frameworks.

3 Requirements

The requirements outlined below represent the activities the contractor will perform.

3.1 Product Management

The contractor must provide senior level product management expertise for FPAC's system modernization and development efforts focusing on but not limited to Acreage Reporting, Farm Program Pilot, NRCS Integrated Field tools (IFT), NRCS Water and Climate Information System (WCIS), One Farmer/One file and Agriculture Foreign Investment Disclosure Act (AFIDA).

Product Management includes:

- Platform vision statement and roadmap based on FPAC business needs
- Platform branding, communications, and value proposition statement to align USDA IT and FPAC business leadership and ensure common objectives of administration, Secretary, and USDA strategic objectives
- Scheduled (bi-weekly) and ad hoc communications support to all FPAC business leadership from OCIO, Platform team, and project team to ensure validity of use cases
- Work with stakeholders to validate use cases, prioritize features and ensure stakeholder alignment to the vision and roadmap

Expertise will be leveraged to help determine applicability and viability of FPAC development efforts on other USDA mission areas and staff offices.

3.2 Human Centered Design

The contractor must provide senior level human centered design (HCD) expertise. HCD includes:

- **Lead Comprehensive User Research:** Plan and execute qualitative and quantitative research (interviews, surveys, usability testing) to deeply understand stakeholder needs across FPAC programs, ensuring insights drive design decisions.
- **Develop Service Design Artifacts:** Create and maintain user journey maps, service blueprints, personas, and workflow diagrams that align with Palantir ontology-driven workflows and USDA modernization objectives.
- **Accessibility and Compliance Expertise:** Ensure all designs meet Section 508 and WCAG standards, embedding accessibility principles into prototypes and final deliverables for inclusive user experiences.
- **Facilitate Co-Creation and Stakeholder Alignment:** Lead collaborative design workshops and ideation sessions with cross-functional teams (OCIO, FPAC business units, Palantir platform teams) to validate concepts and prioritize features.
- **Drive Iterative Design in Agile Delivery:** Champion rapid prototyping, usability testing, and continuous feedback loops within an agile framework to deliver user-centered solutions that adapt to evolving program goals.

4 Deliverables

Table 1: Deliverables

Deliverable	Frequency	Deliver To
Platform vision statement	Coordinate schedule with technical lead post award	Government Technical Lead
Roadmap	Coordinate schedule with technical lead post award	Government Technical Lead
Communications artifacts	Coordinate schedule with technical lead post award	Government Technical Lead

Agile delivery artifacts	Coordinate schedule with technical lead post award	Government Technical Lead
User research and service design artifacts (e.g. customer journey maps, product UX flows, etc).	Coordinate schedule with technical lead post award	Government Human Centered Design Lead

5 Performance Standards

Table 2: Performance Standards

Performance Objective	Performance Standard	Surveillance Method
Monthly Reports	Reports are timely, accurate, concise, and well-formed	Monthly review
Invoices	Invoicing and API feed requirements are met	Monthly review
Bi-Weekly Meetings	Meetings are timely, accurate, concise, and well-formed	Bi-weekly review
Deliverables	Deliverables are consistent, accurate, meet requirements and timelines	Periodic review

6 Key Personnel

During the first ninety (90) days of performance, the Contractor shall make no substitutions of key positions unless the substitution is necessitated by illness, death, or termination of employment. The Contractor shall notify the Contracting Officer within 15 calendar days after the occurrence of any of these events and provide the information required below. After the initial 90-day period, the Contractor shall submit the information required below to the Contracting Officer at least 15 days prior to making any permanent substitutions.

The Contractor shall provide a detailed explanation of the circumstances necessitating the proposed substitutions, complete resumes for the proposed substitutes, and any additional information requested by the Contracting Officer. Proposed substitutes should have comparable qualifications to those of the persons being replaced. The Contracting Officer will notify the Contractor within 15 calendar days after receipt of all required information of the decision on substitutions. The contract will be modified to reflect any approved changes of key personnel.

Unless otherwise agreed upon, the Contractor shall provide an overlap pairing period, of at least 14 calendar days, or as agreed upon by the CO, between outbound and inbound Key Position to ensure continuity and information transfer.

The following key positions apply:

6.1 Senior Product Manager

The senior product manager must have demonstrated experience with the Palantir platform along with excellent communication, problem solving, risk management and stakeholder management skills including executive level leadership. This role is estimated to be approximately 80%.

6.2 Human-Centered Design Lead

The Human-Centered Design Lead must have deep expertise in User Experience/ Human-Centered Design with strong leadership and communication skills to guide projects from user research through ideation, prototyping, and iterative delivery, aligning solutions with USDA program goals in a fast-paced agile delivery environment. This role is estimated to be approximately 50%.

7 Government Furnished Information (GFI)

The Government may provide GFI to the Contractor such as data inputs, customer information, existing platform documentation and business processes. All GFI clauses at the GSA Multiple Award Schedule (MAS) level are applicable at the TO level.

8 Government Furnished Equipment (GFE)

The GSA MAS clauses with respect to GFE flow to the TO.

The following Government furnished equipment will be provided to the Contractor for use in performance of the efforts described herein: One OCIO-issued laptop computer for each personnel, as required.

The Contractor shall be responsible for any loss or damage to the assigned equipment and will be responsible for reimbursement or replacement to the government should loss or damage occurs due to negligence on the employee's part. Access to any documentation on USDA security issues and systems necessary to perform work requested under this task is subject to USDA security policy and procedures. Government will make meeting rooms available as required.

9 Period of Performance

Base Period: Award + 7 months

Option Period 1: 3 months

Option Period 2: 3 months

Option Period 3: 3 months

10 Place of Performance

Work can be performed remotely. Occasional meetings may be needed at USDA locations.

11 Travel

Travel is not anticipated but may be necessary at times and must be approved in advance by the COR. Travel will be reimbursed in accordance with Federal Travel Regulations, unless otherwise specified.

12 Contract Type

The contract type is firm fixed price (FFP).

13 Non-Personal Services

The Government shall neither supervise Contractor employees nor control the method by which the Contractor performs the required tasks. Under no circumstances shall the Government assign tasks to, or prepare work schedules for, individual Contractor employees. It shall be the responsibility of the Contractor to manage its employees and to guard against any actions that are of the nature of personal services or give the perception of personal services. If the Contractor believes that any actions constitute, or are perceived to constitute personal services, it shall be the Contractor's responsibility to notify the Contracting Officer (CO) immediately.

14 Security Requirements

The contractor shall work with USDA to ensure outputs and work products comply with all relevant USDA policies. Externally available policies can be found here: [Directives by Category | USDA](#).

The Contractor and other external organizations will ensure that its employees performing under this contract fulfill all OCIO requirements for mandatory security awareness and role-based advanced security training in accordance with OMB Circular A-130, FISMA, and NIST requirements, and sign all applicable statements of responsibilities. If the Government, the Contractor or other external organization discovers new or unanticipated threats or hazards, or if existing safeguards have ceased to function, the discoverer will immediately bring the situation to the attention of the other party. The Contractor should forward all suspected spam emails directly to SPAM.ABUSE@usda.gov while all other cyber incident related matters should be sent to cyber.incidents@usda.gov.

15 Supply Chain Risk Management

The contractor shall comply with the latest version of the USDA Information and Communication Technology Departmental Regulation DR 3540-004. This DR is available at <https://www.usda.gov/directives/dr-3540-004>.

16 Data Rights

The Government asserts Unlimited Rights to all data produced by the contractor in performance of this PWS. Unlimited Rights as used in this clause, means the rights of the Government to use, disclose, reproduce, prepare derivative works, distribute copies to the public, including by electronic means, and perform publicly and display publicly, in any manner, including by electronic means, and for any purpose whatsoever, and to have or permit others to do so. The contractor agrees not to assert copyright in computer software produced in the performance of this contract without prior written permission of the Government. When such permission is

granted, the Government shall specify appropriate terms, conditions, and submission requirements to assure utilization, dissemination, and commercialization of the data. The contractor, when requested, shall promptly deliver to the Government a duly executed and approved instrument fully confirmatory of all rights to which the Government is entitled.

Data and information developed, entered, and processed in support of this TO shall be considered Government property. All data and/or materials provided to the contractor to accomplish individual deliverables shall be returned to the Government or destroyed at the end of each applicable deliverable, unless the contractor specifically requests and receives approval from the COR to maintain copies of this data. The Contractor is responsible for distributing data and/or materials given to members of the contractor's team.

None of this data will be released to any other Government organization or other organizations of individuals without the express written approval of USDA unless otherwise specified.

17 Section 508

The Vendor shall comply with the standards, policies, and procedures below. In the event of conflicts between the referenced documents and this PWS, the PWS shall take precedence.

Section 508 Accessibility Standards

1) 29 U.S.C. 794d (Rehabilitation Act as amended)

2) 36 CFR 1194 (Section 508 standards)

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3) <http://www.access-board.gov/sec508/508standards.htm> (Section 508 standards)

4) FAR 39.2 (Section 508)

5) <http://www.ocio.usda.gov/document/departmental-regulation-4030-001> (USDA standards, policies, and procedures for Section 508)

In addition, all contract deliverables are subject to these standards.

All web content or communications materials produced, regardless of format (text, audio, video, etc.), must conform to the applicable Section 508 standards to allow Federal employees and members of the public with disabilities comparable access to and use of information and data provided to Federal employees and members of the public without disabilities. All contractors (including sub-contractors) and consultants responsible for preparing or posting content must comply with the applicable Section 508 accessibility standards and, where applicable, those set forth in the referenced policy or standards document above. Remediation of any materials that do not comply with the applicable provisions of 36 CFR Part 1194 as set forth in the PWS shall be the responsibility of the contractor or consultant.

The following Section 508 provisions apply to the products and/or services identified in this PWS:

- 36 CFR Part 1194.21 provisions a-l
- 36 CFR Part 1194.22 provisions a-p

- 36 CFR Part 1194.23 provisions a-k[4]
- 36 CFR Part 1194.24 provisions a-e
- 36 CFR Part 1194.25 provisions a-j[4]
- 36 CFR Part 1194.26 provisions a-d
- 36 CFR Part 1194.31 provisions a-f
- 36 CFR Part 1194.41 provisions a-c

The following Section 508 provisions apply for software development material identified in this PWS:

For software development, software applications, and operating systems the Vendor shall comply with the following standards, policies, and procedures:

Section 508 Accessibility Standards

- 1) 29 U.S.C. 794d (Rehabilitation Act as amended)
- 2) 36 CFR 1194 (Section 508 standards)
 - a. 36 CFR Part 1194.21 provisions a-l
 - b. 36 CFR Part 1194.31 provisions a-f
 - c. 36 CFR Part 1194.41 provisions a-c

For web-based applications (intranet, internet information and applications, 16 rules), the Vendor shall comply with the following standards, policies, and procedures:

Section 508 Accessibility Standards

- 1) 29 U.S.C. 794d (Rehabilitation Act as amended)
- 2) 36 CFR 1194 (Section 508 standards)
 - a. 36 CFR Part 1194.21 provisions a-l
 - b. 36 CFR Part 1194.22 provisions a-p
 - c. 36 CFR Part 1194.31 provisions a-f
 - d. 36 CFR Part 1194.41 provisions a-c

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For video and multimedia applications (including training materials), the Vendor shall comply with the following standards, policies, and procedures:

Section 508 Accessibility Standards

- 1) 29 U.S.C. 794d (Rehabilitation Act as amended)
- 2) 36 CFR 1194 (Section 508 standards)
 - a. 36 CFR Part 1194.24 provisions a-e

b. 36 CFR Part 1194.31 provisions a-f

c. 36 CFR Part 1194.41 provisions a-c

For self-contained and closed products, the Vendor shall comply with the following standards, policies, and procedures:

Section 508 Accessibility Standards

1) 29 U.S.C. 794d (Rehabilitation Act as amended)

2) 36 CFR 1194 (Section 508 standards)

a. 36 CFR Part 1194.21 provisions a-l

b. 36 CFR Part 1194.25 provisions a-j

c. 36 CFR Part 1194.31 provisions a-f

d. 36 CFR Part 1194.41 provisions a-c

For desktop and portable computers, the Vendor shall comply with the following standards, policies, and procedures:

Section 508 Accessibility Standards

1) 29 U.S.C. 794d (Rehabilitation Act as amended)

2) 36 CFR 1194 (Section 508 standards)

a. 36 CFR Part 1194.21 provisions a-l

b. 36 CFR Part 1194.26 provisions a-d

c. 36 CFR Part 1194.31 provisions a-f

d. 36 CFR Part 1194.41 provisions a-c

For help desk and other support services, the Vendor shall comply with the following standards, policies, and procedures:

Section 508 Accessibility Standards

1) 29 U.S.C. 794d (Rehabilitation Act as amended)

2) 36 CFR 1194 (Section 508 standards)

a. 36 CFR Part 1194.31 provisions a-f

b. 36 CFR Part 1194.41 provisions a-c

If the help desk or other support services include training, Vendor must also comply with the following standards, policies, and procedures in addition to 36 CFR Part 1194.31 provisions a-f and 36 CFR Part 1194.41 provisions a-c:

a. 36 CFR Part 1194.21 provisions a-l (installable and web-based training)

b. 36 CFR Part 1194.22 provisions a-p (web-based software)

All Information and Communications Technology (ICT) subject to the 36 CFR 1194 standards will have a Section 508 usability and acceptance test where Section 508 compliance will be validated. This test must be administered by a Federal Section 508 Testing Center.

All maintenance for Information and Communications Technology that requires upgrades, modifications, installations, and purchases will adhere to the Section 508 standards and 36 CFR 1194.

18 Invoicing

- Invoices shall be submitted electronically through the Department of Treasury's Invoice Processing Platform (IPP). The contractor shall follow Government provided IPP instructions on how to register and submit invoices via IPP as prescribed at the IPP website <https://www.ipp.gov>.
- Additional Information regarding what constitutes a proper invoice can be found by reviewing the Prompt Payment Act (31 USC Chapter 32 - Prompt Payment Act).
- A complete contractor-generated invoice shall be provided electronically as an attachment via IPP.
- The Contractor shall submit any other information or documentation required by other clauses of the Task Order to support the invoice. Original receipts shall be maintained by the Contractor and made available to Government auditors upon request.
- Contractors shall comply with the government's invoicing period, which runs from the first through the last day of the calendar month. Contractors shall invoice the government in arrears for every month services are provided, by the 15th day of the following month. All invoicing shall be rendered based on calendar month cycles.
- Proration: When applicable, monthly charges will be prorated by the number of days the service was performed divided by the number of days in that month.
- Rounding: all charges will be rounded to two (2) decimal places.
- *In addition to submitting information and a PDF invoice to IPP, the contractor must send a congruent set of data via API to USDA OCIO by the 15th day of the following month using the invoice data feed format. The total(s) in the invoices must match IPP totals for reconciliation between IPP, invoice data feed, and TO operational data.*
- The main Billing Line Detail Categories for Pool 2 are limited to: Professional Services (Labor Hour), Professional Services (Training), Professional Services (FFP Service Support), ODC.

19 Reporting

The Contractor shall comply with all USDA reporting requirements.

20 Restrictions against Disclosure

The Contractor agrees, in the performance of this contract, to keep all information contained in source documents or other media furnished by the Government in the strictest confidence. The Contractor also agrees not to publish or otherwise divulge such information in whole or in part, in any manner or form, nor to authorize or permit others to do so, taking such reasonable measures as are necessary to restrict access to such information while in the Contractor's possession, to those employees needing such information to perform the work provided herein, i.e., on a "need to know" basis. The Contractor agrees to immediately notify the Contracting Officer, in writing, in the event that the Contractor determines or has reason to suspect a breach of this requirement.

The Contractor agrees not to disclose any information concerning work under this contract to any persons or individual unless prior written approval is obtained from the Contracting Officer. The Contractor agrees to insert the substance of this clause in any consultant agreement or subcontract hereunder.

21 Inspection and Acceptance

Inspection and acceptance of all work performance, reports, and other deliverables under this TO shall be performed by the Government technical lead(s) and COR at USDA/OCIO.

All deliverables will be inspected for content, completeness, accuracy, and conformance to Contract requirements. Inspection may include validation of information or deliverables (e.g. reports) through the use of automated tools, testing, or inspections of the deliverables, as specified in the Contract. The scope and nature of this inspection will be sufficiently comprehensive to ensure the completeness, quality, and adequacy of all deliverables.

The Government requires a period Not to Exceed (NTE) 15 workdays after receipt of final deliverable items for inspection and acceptance or rejection. Non-conforming products or services will be rejected. Deficiencies will be corrected, by the Contractor, within 10 workdays of the rejection notice. If the deficiencies cannot be corrected within 10 workdays, the Contractor will immediately notify the COR of the reason for the delay and provide a proposed corrective action plan within 10 workdays.

- Lead the development of the Platform Vision Statement and Roadmap based on USDA and FPAC business needs.
- Align Platform Branding, Communications, and Value Proposition Statements with USDA IT and FPAC Business Leadership to ensure common objectives of administration, Secretary, and USDA strategic objectives.
- Work with stakeholders to validate use cases, prioritize features, and ensure stakeholder alignment to the Landmark vision and roadmap.

- Provide at least bi-weekly and ad hoc communications support to OCIO, FPAC leadership, and others as designated.